INTRODUCTION

BACK TO THE CAVE

In 2008, the first *Iron Man* film launched a franchise—and along with it, a whole new way of looking at super-hero movies. Audiences loved the action, the humor, the subtle social commentary, and the flawed character of Tony Stark, played to perfection by Robert Downey Jr. On every level, the film was a success.

But another factor also caught viewers' attention, intriguing them with the promise of a different kind of cinematic experience. From that very first Marvel film, it was clear that Tony Stark was part of a larger universe. Taking a cue from their source material—the Marvel comics that had captivated readers for decades—Marvel Studios crafted that cinematic universe one piece at a time, through *The Incredible Hulk*, *Iron Man 2*, *Thor*, and *Captain America: The First Avenger*. These characters ultimately came together in the ultra-blockbuster *Marvel's The Avengers*, which broke box-office records, thrilling audiences and critics around the world.

Flash forward to today. *Iron Man 3* is the third entry in a popular trilogy, but it's also the studio's first film following the success of *Marvel's The Avengers*. This situation posed a unique series of challenges.

"The film is the start of something new *and* bringing something to a close, so it's trying to do two things at once," says Stephen Broussard, Executive Producer of *Iron Man 3*. "And much like the first *Iron Man* movie was about launching Marvel Studios as its own independent entity, *Iron Man 3* has the burden of being the first post-*Avengers* movie, to set the tone for what that could mean."

So how did the filmmakers approach this challenge? How do you follow up the spectacular, multiple-character team-up action of *Marvel's The Avengers*, in which Iron Man fought alongside gods and monsters against a massive alien invasion?

The answer: Take Tony Stark back to the cave.



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